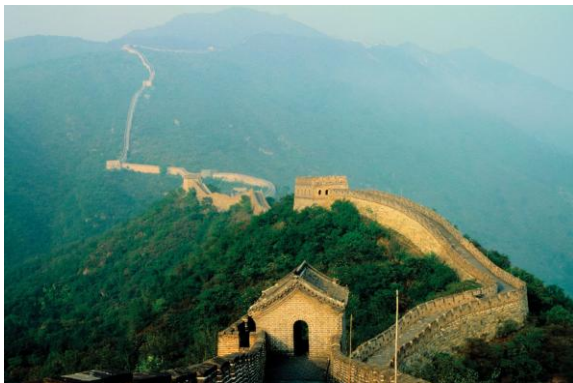


New Seven Wonders of the World

In 2000 a Swiss foundation launched a campaign to determine the New Seven Wonders of the World. Given that the original [Seven Wonders](#) list was compiled in the 2nd century BCE—and that only one entrant is still standing (the [Pyramids of Giza](#))—it seemed time for an update. And people around the world apparently agreed, as more than 100 million votes were cast on the Internet or by [text messaging](#). The final results, which were announced in 2007, were met with cheers as well as some jeers—a number of prominent [contenders](#), such as [Athens's Acropolis](#), failed to make the cut. Do you agree with the new list?

Great Wall of China

Great might be an understatement. One of the world's largest building-construction projects, the [Great Wall of China](#) is widely thought to be about 5,500 miles (8,850 km) long; a disputed Chinese study, however, claims the length is 13,170 miles (21,200 km). Work began in the 7th century BCE and continued for two millennia. Although called a “wall,” the structure actually features two parallel walls for lengthy stretches. In addition, watchtowers and barracks dot the [bulwark](#). One not-so-great thing about the wall, however, was its effectiveness. Although it was built to prevent invasions and raids, the wall largely failed to provide actual security. Instead, scholars have noted that it served more as “political propaganda.”



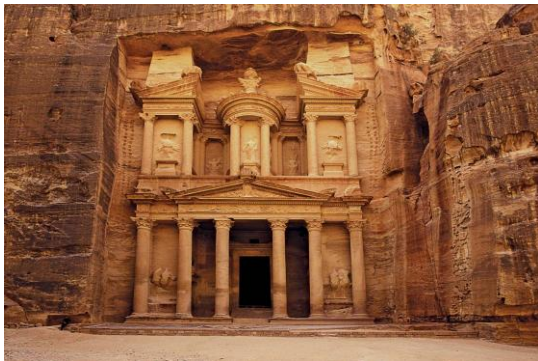
Chichén Itzá

[Chichén Itzá](#) is a [Mayan](#) city on the [Yucatán Peninsula](#) in [Mexico](#), which flourished in the 9th and 10th centuries CE. Under the Mayan tribe Itzá—who were strongly influenced by the [Toltecs](#)—a number of important monuments and temples were built. Among the most notable is the stepped pyramid El Castillo (“The Castle”), which rises 79 feet (24 meters) above the Main Plaza. A [testament](#) to the Mayans’ [astronomical](#) abilities, the structure features a total of 365 steps, the number of days in the solar year. During the spring and autumnal equinoxes, the setting sun casts shadows on the pyramid that give the appearance of a serpent slithering down the north stairway; at the base is a stone snake head. Life there was not all work and [science](#), however. Chichén Itzá is home to the largest [tlachtli](#) (a type of sporting field) in the Americas. On that field the residents played a ritual ball game popular throughout pre-Columbian Mesoamerica.



Petra

The ancient city of [Petra, Jordan](#), is located in a remote valley, nestled among sandstone mountains and cliffs. It was purported to be one of the places where [Moses](#) struck a rock and water gushed forth. Later the [Nabataeans](#), an Arab tribe, made it their capital, and during this time it [flourished](#), becoming an important trade center, especially for spices. Noted carvers, the Nabataeans chiseled dwellings, temples, and tombs into the sandstone, which changed color with the shifting sun. In addition, they constructed a water system that allowed for lush gardens and farming. At its height, Petra reportedly had a population of 30,000. The city began to decline, however, as trade routes shifted. A major earthquake in 363 CE caused more difficulty, and after another tremor hit in 551, Petra was gradually abandoned. Although rediscovered in 1912, it was largely ignored by archaeologists until the late 20th century, and many questions remain about the city.



Machu Picchu

This [Incan](#) site near [Cuzco, Peru](#), was “discovered” in 1911 by [Hiram Bingham](#), who believed it was Vilcabamba, a secret Incan [stronghold](#) used during the 16th-century rebellion against Spanish rule. Although that claim was later disproved, the purpose of [Machu Picchu](#) has confounded scholars. Bingham believed it was home to the “[Virgins of the Sun](#),” women who lived in convents under a vow of chastity. Others think that it was likely a pilgrimage site, while some believe it was a royal retreat. (One thing it apparently should not be is the site of a beer commercial. In 2000 a crane being used for such an ad fell and cracked a monument.) What is known is that Machu Picchu is one of the few major [pre-Columbian](#) ruins found nearly intact. Despite its relative isolation high in the [Andes Mountains](#), it features agricultural [terraces](#), plazas, residential areas, and temples.

